

SMARTLEARN AI - ACADEMIC SYSTEM

Program: BA English Literature | Course Materials

Course Overview: Hamlet, Prince of Denmark

The Tragedy of Hamlet, Prince of Denmark, written by William Shakespeare between 1599 and 1601, is one of the most influential and performed plays in the history of world literature. Set in Denmark, the play depicts Prince Hamlet and his attempts to exact revenge upon his uncle Claudius, who has murdered Hamlet's father in order to seize the throne and marry Hamlet's mother.

This study guide focuses on structural elements, soliloquies, thematic shifts, and character relationships.

Key Thematic Foundations

1. REVENGE VS. HESITATION: Hamlet's defining struggle is his inability to take swift action to avenge his father, exploring the moral, psychological, and philosophical complexities of revenge.
2. MADNESS: The play constantly keeps the audience guessing whether Hamlet's madness is entirely a performance ('antic disposition') or a genuine mental collapse.
3. MORTALITY AND DECAY: Highlighting the corruption of Elsinore ('Something is rotten in the state of Denmark') and Hamlet's obsession with death, exemplified in his famous Yorick skull soliloquy.

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Thematic Essay Assignment Questions

For your mid-semester evaluation, select one of the following topics for a 1,500-word critical analysis:

Topic A: Evaluate the structural function of play-within-a-play ('The Mousetrap') in exposing Claudius's guilt.

Topic B: Detail Ophelia's descent into madness and how it contrasts with Hamlet's feigned mental instability.

Topic C: Analyze the character of Horatio as the voice of reason and the only surviving witness to the tragedy.